BJP and Hindu activists barged into the school on July 16, demanding that its licence be cancelled.

Hyderabad police and education department officials are investigating the episode. But the controversy scaled up further as Union minister Bandi Sanjay and Telangana BJP chief Ramchander Rao jumped in, condemning it as a conversion mafia's attack on Hindu culture, enabled directly by the Congress regime's "minority appeasement" approach. "What we witnessed in Saidabad is not an isolated incident. These are the ways by which schools run by certain sections indulge in conversions," Rao told INDIA TODAY.

Neither the Congress nor the AIMIM leaders have reacted yet. The BJP has been gaining ground in Telangana in recent years—it holds eight out of its 17 Lok Sabha seats. In the 2020 polls to the Greater Hyderabad Municipal Corporation, the saffron party's tally had surged from four to 48 in a total of 150 wards. Capable of self-harm through internal squabbles, the 'school jihad' cases are a godsend for the party, a BJP leader tells INDIA TODAY. A city autorickshaw with a 'Jai Shri Ram' slogan, whose driver was allegedly assaulted, became part of the frame as Sanjay bought him a new auto—driving it himself for a few miles. Maybe the narrative will travel further: up to the assembly polls in 2028. ■



ALAMY

KALINGA CONNECT Shanti stupa at Dhauli. The new Tarpan Sheela Stambh is coming up nearby

▶ ODISHA

ODISHA AWAKES ITS PAST

The homes of its progenitors, a Kalinga statue, a seaside Tagore nest—Odisha renews its heritage

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

IN HIS FIFTH AND LAST TERM AS CHIEF MINISTER BEGINNING 2019, Biju Janata Dal supremo Naveen Patnaik had staked a lot of political capital on what seemed an unlikely project for him—an ambitious redevelopment of Odisha's temple ecosystem. Its flagship, the Puri heritage corridor, was in fact conceived in 2016—among the first in a rash of projects across India. Now, two years after coming to power on the plank of Odia pride, the BJP government is embossing its own stamp on heritage. Hundreds of crores of rupees are being poured into projects designed to preserve historical memory, celebrate regional icons and strengthen Odia identity.

The most ambitious of these initiatives is the Baraputra Aitihya Gram Yojana, under which the state plans to develop the native villages, birthplaces and residences of eminent Odia personalities and historical figures—25 to begin with. With an allocation of Rs 15 crore for each site, the programme is expected to transform these locations into "living heritage spaces". The idea is "not simply conservation", says an official in the culture department. "We want people, especially